



European history, often corresponded to the assumed superiority of the man mounted to the man on foot. But even in the hierarchical Aztec, Inca, or Maya societies of pre-Columbian America, in which there were no horses, the elite aristocratic warriors were sharply distinguished from a mass of lowly stone-throwers.

PRACTICAL FIGHTERS

Unfortunately for the aristocratic warrior, who regarded war as an arena for personal feats of valour, warfare was always fundamentally a practical activity, in which the question of winning or losing could determine the future of whole societies. History repeatedly shows examples of men from the lower orders, properly organized and equipped, outfighting the warrior elites through a less individualistic, more down-to-earth approach to war. The legions of the Roman Empire established the paradigm for a professional force of career-soldiers recruited from the lower ranks of society and trained up to a high level of military effectiveness. These were men instilled with a strong sense of duty and devotion to the honour of their legion, as well as being subject to rigorous discipline. They had no ambition to achieve individual glory, only the more modest goal of promotion within a hierarchy of rank. When Europe's modern standing armies developed in the 17th and 18th centuries, discipline and drill were again at the heart of their effort to transform men often viewed by their officers as the scum of society into brave and reliable fighting men. The warrior principles of honour and glory were not forgotten, since the regimental system made the soldiers part of an enduring organization with whose banners and reputation they could identify. But individual initiative and fighting flair were strictly repressed. These uniformed armies made fixed hierarchies of rank and unhesitating obedience to orders the essence of military life.

CITIZEN-SOLDIERS

The concept of the citizen-soldier we owe to the Ancient Greeks. In Athens in the 5th century BCE, donning armour as an unpaid hoplite heavy infantryman was both a duty and a privilege of status as a free citizen. This was an idea that much appealed to modern Europeans when they



